



Guidelines

Suppression of Patient Information – Request for Anonymity

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
SCGOPHCG	Organisation Wide	All Staff

Introduction

The aim of this guideline is to outline the process for managing requests for patient anonymity whilst in the care of the Sir Charles Gairdner Osborne Park Healthcare Group (SCGOPHCG).

Risk Statement

Non-compliance with this guideline will:

Breach legislative requirements	☐	Impact on Patient Quality of Care	☐
Breach National/State/Hospital Policy	☐	Impact on Patient Safety	☒
Breach professional standards	☒	Misconduct	☐
Breach SCGOPHCG Mission & Values	☐	Staff Safety	☒
Other:	☐		

Background

Patients can elect to restrict visitors and request anonymity. There are also occasions where the decision to suppress information or restrict visitors is initiated by Western Australian Police or the Department of Corrections.

A suppression of information request, from a patient or other entity, must be documented in the patient's medical record and the Patient Administration System (webPAS).

The suppression of patient information request is restricted to the current admission and is only effective until the patient's discharge from hospital.

Patient Request for Anonymity

Staff receiving a request from a patient to suppress their information are to advise the Senior Registered Nurse (SRN) or Medical Officer or After-hours SRN who, as per the checklist on page two of the Patient Request for Anonymity form (MR 601.1), will discuss this request with the patient.

Patients who make an anonymity request must be advised that it will apply to all enquiries, and they cannot provide a list of exempted visitors.

Once the reason(s) for anonymity has been established and approved it must be documented on the form which is to be signed by the patient. The patient is to be provided a photocopy of the signed form.

The Ward Clerk must be notified immediately to suppress the information on webPAS, which will then display an information suppression indicator on the patient's admission record. After-hours, contact the Patient Master Index (PMI) team on 74771 to have webPAS updated. The form is to be scanned and emailed to Switchboard via nmhs.switchboardoperations@health.wa.gov.au

At any time during the admission if the patient decides to rescind the request for anonymity, it must be documented on the form and updated on webPAS and at Switchboard.

Other Requests for Anonymity

If the request for anonymity is made by Western Australian Police or Department of Corrective Services or where a court has issued a restraining order in relation to the patient, a copy of any documentation, including the Patient Request for Anonymity form, is placed in the correspondence section of the patient's medical record. The suppression of information can also be initiated by the hospital Executive Director or Medical Executive on-call for safety/privacy or practical reasons.

If the requesting body decides to lift the anonymity request, this must be disclosed to the patient and implications discussed.

Visitors

Security must be notified if visitors present with knowledge of the suppressed patient's location.

Outside of anonymity requests, switchboard operators are not responsible for communicating visitor restrictions. Callers will be transferred to the ward where they will be informed if any restrictions apply.

Breaches of anonymity requests

Best efforts will be made to uphold anonymity requests, including but not limited to visitors and telephone enquiries.

If there is a breach of the request, the Medical Officer or SRN or After-hours SRN must discuss this with the patient as soon as possible. A decision is to be made whether to continue or cancel the request, or to explore alternative strategies to maintain safety for the patient and hospital staff.

Related Documents

[Patient Request for Anonymity Form](#)

Authorisation & Version Control

Policy Sponsor	Area Director Clinical Services				
Policy Contact	Manager, Health Information Management Services				
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Standards Applicable	Insert relevant NSQHS Standards (Version 2):  				

For full details regarding, development, review, consultation, approval, endorsement - contact the Policy Officer for the submission form

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